and natural disasters easy to understand. Anything that happens – even a pandemic – is about elites pursuing power. Second, the populist view is attractive because it is sometimes correct. Every human institution is indeed fallible and suffers from some level of corruption. Some judges do take bribes. Some journalists do intentionally mislead the public. Academic disciplines are occasionally plagued by bias and nepotism. That is why every institution needs self-correcting mechanisms. But since populists are convinced that power is the only reality, they cannot accept that a court, a media outlet or an academic discipline would ever be inspired by the value of truth or justice to correct itself.

While many people embrace populism because they see it as an honest account of human reality, strongmen are attracted to it for a different reason. Populism offers strongmen an ideological basis for making themselves dictators while pretending to be democrats. It is particularly useful when strongmen seek to neutralise or appropriate the self-correcting mechanisms of democracy. Since judges, journalists and professors allegedly pursue political interests rather than truth, the people's champion – the strongman – should control these positions instead of allowing them to fall into the hands of the people's enemies. Similarly, since even the officials in charge of arranging elections and publicising their results may be part of a nefarious conspiracy, they too should be replaced by the strongman's loyalists.

In a well-functioning democracy, citizens trust the results of elections, the decisions of courts, the reports of media outlets and the findings of scientific disciplines because citizens believe these institutions are committed to the truth. Once people think that power is the only reality, they lose trust in all these institutions, democracy collapses, and the strongmen can seize total power.

Of course, populism could lead to anarchy rather than totalitarianism, if it undermines trust in the strongmen themselves. If no human is interested in truth or justice, doesn't this apply to Mussolini or Putin too? And if no human institution can have effective self-correcting mechanisms, doesn't this include Mussolini's National Fascist Party or Putin's United Russia party? How can a deep-seated distrust of all elites and institutions be squared with unwavering admiration for one leader and party? This is why populists ultimately depend on the mystical notion that the strongman embodies the people. When trust in bureaucratic institutions like election